

Poem-1 My Mother at Sixty-Six by Kamala Das

Enjambment

One of the most important poetic devices used in this poem is enjambment. Das does not use any full stop marks throughout the text, even at the end. There is an ellipsis (...) at the end of the last line. The poet enjambes the lines to create a chain of thoughts. Each line proceeds to the following one to complete the idea, continuing until the end.

Alliteration

It occurs in the phrase “**my mother**” in the very title. The “m” sound gets repeated at the beginning of these words. As the consonant sound is repeated, it is also an example of consonance. It can also be found in the phrase, “**Sixty-Six**” (Here, the “i” sound also gets repeated; an example of assonance as well). Now, let’s have a look at some specific examples of consonance and assonance from the text.

Consonance

By Thunderstudy

- “I saw **my mother**,/ beside **me**,”
- “face/ **ashen**” (listen to the repetition of the soft “s” sound; it’s called sibilance)
- “**she** was as old as **she**/ looked but **soon**” (another instance of sibilance)
- “**Young**/ Trees **sprinting**”
- “but all I said was, see you soon, Amma,/ all I did was **smile** and **smile** and/ **smile**.....”
(Now ask yourself, why does the poet use the “s” sound so frequently? It’s because the sound not only has a soothing effect but it also resonates with the sad mental state of the speaker)

Assonance

- “**home** to **Cochin**” (Remember: the “o” at the end of “to” isn’t pronounced as the “o” in “home.” It sounds like an unstressed “ah,” called schwa.)
- “**doze**, **open**”
- “**ashen** like **that**”
- “**looked** but **soon**”
- “**Trees** **sprinting**, the merry children **spilling**” (Listen to the uplifting effect of the long “i” sound; have you noticed there is also a consonance in “**sprinting**” and “**spilling**.” How beautifully Kamala Das wove this piece!)
- “**pale**/ as a **late**”

Simile

- It occurs in the lines, “her face/ ashen like that/ of a corpse.” The poet explicitly compares the color of her mother’s face to that of a corpse. The pale old face of her mother also makes the poet think about her impending death. She visualizes the image of funeral ashes while staring at her aging mother.
- In “that she was **as** old **as** she/ looked,” the speaker compares the physical features of her mother to the external signs of aging by using the linker “as.”
- In “I looked again at her, wan, pale/ **as** a late winter’s moon,” the speaker compares her mother’s light-colored face to a “late winter’s moon.” She uses the image of the moon to depict the similarities between the color of her aging mother’s face and that of the moon in late winter, which looks light white from the earth due to the dense cold air.

Personification

It occurs in “Young/ Trees sprinting.” The poet capitalizes the first letters of these words, “Young” and “Trees.” She does so by personifying the trees with the idea of being young and sprinting. The phrase also contains a personal metaphor, “Young.” This adjective is also used to compare the trees with young kids.

Metaphor

- There is an interesting metaphor in the line, “the merry children spilling/ out of their homes.” The energy and spontaneity of children are compared to a glass full of liquid. The glass or the container is their home, and the kids are the essence that fills their home with laughter and joy. By looking at the kids, it seems they are spilling out their energy while coming out of their homes to play.
- The phrase “late winter’s moon” contains a metaphor too. Through this phrase, the poet portrays the pale-white color of the moon during winter’s end. It is comparable to the face of an aged person.

Metonymy

- The phrase “merry children” is a metonym/symbol of innocence, freshness, liveliness, and hope. The variety used here is a symbol for the thing symbolized.
- We can find a similar use of metonymy in the phrase “late winter’s moon.” It is a metonym for death and old age.

Tautology

It occurs in “away, I looked again at her, **wan, pale.**” “Wan” and “pale” both have the same meanings. When a writer repeats words having a similar meaning, it is called tautology in rhetorics.

Palilogy and Polysyndeton

In the last lines, “all I did was smile and smile and/ smile ...” readers can find two literary devices. Firstly, the conjunction “and” is used twice for the sake of emphasis. It is called polysyndeton. Secondly, the same word “smile” is repeated thrice. It is called a palilogy. These two poetic devices are grouped as figures based on construction.

Poem-2 Keeping Quiet –by Pablo Neruda

1. **Alliteration:** It is the repetition of consonant sounds at the beginning of words. e.g. “*we will count*”, “*sudden strangeness*”, “*stop for one second*”, “*his hurt hands*”, “*clean clothes*”.
2. **Repetition:** It is the repetition of phrases in the poem for poetic effect. e.g. “*without rush, without engines*”.
3. **Symbolism:** The poet uses various symbols in the poem. e.g. “Brothers” symbolise mankind, “green wars” refer to deforestation, “wars with gas” refers to pollution, “clean clothes” symbolise change of perspective, “shade” symbolises protection etc.
4. **Antithesis:** It is the juxtaposition of opposing or contrasting ideas. e.g. “count to twelve and we will all keep still”. Here counting and keeping still are contrasting activities and are put together.
5. **Personification:** it is the attribution of human characteristics to non-human things and animals. e.g. “*Earth can teach us as when everything*”.
6. **Metaphor:** It is used to make a comparison between two things that aren’t alike but do have something in common. e.g. “shade” refers to protection.
7. **Enjambment:** It is the continuation of a sentence to the next line/stanza. In the poem, many sentences continue to multiple lines. e.g. “Now we will count to twelve and we will all keep still.”, “For once on the face of the Earth let’s not speak in any language, let’s stop for one second, and not move our arms so much.” etc.

Poem-3 A Thing of Beauty –by John Keats

Metaphor:

- **bower** - a calm, pleasant shade
- **sweet dreams** - happy dreams
- **flowery band** - to bind us to earth
- **pall** - a cloth covering/a cloud of dust, smoke
- **endless fountain of immortal drink** - a shower of blessings of good health

Alliteration:

- A flowery **band** to **bind** us to the earth,
- Spite of **despondence**, of the inhuman **dearth**
- **Some shape** of beauty moves away the pall.
- From our dark **spirits**. **Such** the **sun**, the moon,

- Trees old and young, **sprouting** a **shady** boon
- For **simple** **sheep**; and **such** are daffodils
- **That** for **themselves** a **cooling** **covert** make
- 'Gainst **the** hot season; **the** mid forest brake,
- **Rich** with a sprinkling of fair musk-**rose** blooms:

Imagery:

Imagery means using **imaginative language** to represent **objects**, **actions**, and **ideas** in such a way that it **appeals** to our **physical senses**. A writer helps the reader to **visualize** or to **see** in their minds what is being described. The images should appeal to **one or more of the five senses**: sight, hearing, touch, taste or smell.

- A **flowery band** to bind us to the earth
- **Some shape of beauty moves** away the pall
- From our dark spirits. **Such the sun, the moon,**
- Trees old and young, **sprouting a shady boon**
- With the **green world** they live in; and clear rills
- That for themselves a **cooling covert** make
- Rich with a **sprinkling of fair musk-rose blooms**
- An **endless fountain** of immortal drink
- **Pouring unto us** from the heaven's brink

Anaphora: Use of same word in two consecutive lines. Anaphora serves the purpose of delivering an artistic effect to a passage. Eg. **Of** noble natures- **Of** all the unhealthy

Inversion: The normal order of words is reversed. Eg. (Are we wreathing a flowery band)

Antithesis: opposite words placed together. Eg. Old and young

Poem-4 A Roadside Stand –by Robert Frost

Transferred Epithet:

There are two examples of transferred epithet in “A Roadside Stand.”

1. ‘polished traffic’ referring to the city dwellers who pass by the countryside and sometimes they take out a moment to scrutinize the surroundings around them.
2. ‘Selfish cars’ is yet another use of a transferred epithet. This refers to the car owners who do stop at the roadside stand but to ask about the police or the gas stations.

Personification:

“the sadness that lurks behind the open window there...” where sadness is an example of

personification. Sadness dwells in the windows of the farmers because they wait for cars to stop and make a purchase.

Alliteration and Oxymoron: ‘Greedy good doers’ and ‘beneficent beasts of prey’ are examples of both alliteration and oxymoron.

Metaphor

1. Trusting Sorrow

Poem-5 Aunt Jennifer's Tigers –by Adrienne Rich

Allusions

The poem alludes to Blake's poem "The Tyger," which describes a "bright" tiger in a forest. Jennifer's gemlike tigers in a world of green call up this famous image. "The Tyger" ends by asking "What immortal hand or eye,/dare frame thy fearful symmetry"—in other words, who would be brave enough to create an animal as strange and terrifying as the tiger? Here, Rich answers that question in a surprising way—it is the terrified hand of a mortal woman who creates the proud and fearless tiger.

Imagery: Imagery is used to make readers perceive things involving their five senses. Adrienne Rich used imagery in this poem, such as “They pace in sleek chivalric certainty”, “Find even the ivory needle hard to pull” and “Still ringed with ordeals she was mastered by.”

Synecdoche

Synecdoche: Aunt Jennifer's wedding ring stands in for her marriage as a whole.

Hyperbole

Rich uses hyperbole when she refers to "the massive weight of Uncle's wedding band," wildly exaggerating the physical weight of the object in order to emphasize its spiritual weight on Aunt Jennifer's life.

Foreshadowing

In the first stanza, Rich writes that the tigers "do not fear the men beneath the tree," foreshadowing Aunt Jennifer's fear of her husband.

Irony

The poem centers around the situational irony of Aunt Jennifer embroidering an image of "proud and unafraid" tigers while she is weak and terrified. This irony is heightened by fact that embroidery is a craft heavily associated with traditional womanhood.

Alliteration and Assonance

In line 4, the phrase "sleek chivalric certainty" alliterates the /s/ sound.

In lines 11-12, "The tigers in the panel that she made/Will go on prancing, proud and unafraid," the /p/ sound is alliterated.

Consonance: Consonance is the repetition of consonant sounds in the same line, such as the sound of /d/ in "When Aunt is dead, her terrified hands will lie" and the sound of /s/ in "They pace in sleek chivalric certainty."

Metaphors and Similes

In the third stanza, Rich uses the word "ringed" metaphorically, to describe being enclosed or imprisoned. However, she also draws on the literal meaning of the word, through the connection between Jennifer's lack of freedom as a married woman, and her wedding ring.

Symbolism: Symbolism is using symbols to signify ideas and qualities, giving them symbolic meanings that are different from the literal meanings. The poem shows symbols such as the green, topaz, finger, and wool to show the world of women undergoing oppression.

By Thunderstudy